

# Carvaka: Quick Revision Notes

UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper I | Indian Philosophy

**Focus:** perception, rejection of inference/transcendent entities, and materialism

## One-line Essence

Carvaka is an empiricist and materialist school that accepts perception alone as valid knowledge and rejects soul, God, karma, rebirth, and afterlife as imperceptible and epistemologically unjustified.

## Core Chain to Remember

Perception alone -> rejection of inference/testimony -> rejection of transcendent entities -> materialism -> this-worldly ethics

## Subtopic Snapshot

| Area        | Exam-ready point                                                                                       |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| School      | Heterodox / Nastika school; rejects Vedic authority.                                                   |
| Pramana     | Accepts perception alone as the valid pramana.                                                         |
| Inference   | Rejected as an independent pramana because it depends on vyapti, which cannot be known with certainty. |
| Testimony   | Rejected when it claims knowledge of imperceptible realities, especially scriptural claims.            |
| Metaphysics | Rejects God, eternal soul, karma, rebirth, heaven, hell, and moksha as not validly established.        |
| Materialism | Matter alone is real; self is identified with the living body; consciousness arises from the body.     |
| Ethics      | This-worldly pleasure and well-being matter because post-death rewards are not established.            |

## 1. Perception as the Only Valid Pramana

- **Pramana** means valid means of knowledge.
- Carvaka accepts **perception**, i.e., direct sense-experience, as the only certain pramana.
- What is not established by perception is not accepted as validly known.
- This is why Carvaka is called empiricist in Indian philosophy.

## 2. Rejection of Inference

Carvaka's criticism of inference is based on the problem of **vyapti**.

|                         |                                                                                                                                 |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Inference</b>        | Indirect knowledge through a sign, e.g., smoke -> fire.                                                                         |
| <b>Vyapti</b>           | Universal and invariable relation, e.g., wherever there is smoke, there is fire.                                                |
| <b>Carvaka critique</b> | All cases across all times and places cannot be perceived; hence vyapti cannot be known with certainty.                         |
| <b>Conclusion</b>       | Inference is rejected as an independent means of certain philosophical knowledge, especially for proving transcendent entities. |

## 3. Rejection of Testimony

- Testimony means knowledge based on words, authority, or scripture.
- Carvaka rejects scriptural testimony because it speaks of imperceptible entities.
- Claims about heaven, hell, unseen merit, sin, and ritual rewards are not perceptually established.

## 4. Rejection of Transcendent Entities

Transcendent entities are realities said to exist beyond ordinary sense-experience.

| Entity               | Carvaka reason for rejection                                                 |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| God                  | Not perceived; usually proved through inference or scripture, both rejected. |
| Eternal soul         | No separate soul is perceived apart from the living body.                    |
| Karma                | Unseen moral force is not an object of perception.                           |
| Rebirth              | No post-death continuation of the soul is perceived.                         |
| Heaven, hell, moksha | All presuppose a continuing soul after death; hence rejected.                |

## 5. Materialism and Ethics

- Materialism means **matter alone is real**.
- Carvaka identifies the self with the living body, not an eternal soul.
- Consciousness is treated as a product of material elements, not as proof of a separate soul.
- Since afterlife and karmic rewards are not established, present embodied life becomes central.
- Its ethics is this-worldly: worldly happiness and well-being are valued.

### Avoid These Common Mistakes

| Weak / risky statement                    | Better UPSC formulation                                                                |
|-------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Carvaka proved that soul does not exist.  | Carvaka rejects soul because it is not validly established by perception.              |
| Carvaka rejects all inference.            | Carvaka rejects inference as an independent source of certain philosophical knowledge. |
| Carvaka is just eat, drink, and be merry. | Carvaka's this-worldly ethics follows from materialism and rejection of afterlife.     |
| Carvaka is only anti-religious.           | Carvaka is a systematic empiricist and materialist critique of metaphysics.            |

### 150-word Answer Skeleton

**Intro:** Carvaka, also called Lokayata, is the major materialist and heterodox school of Indian philosophy. It rejects Vedic authority and accepts perception alone as the valid pramana.

**Body:** Its epistemology forms the basis of its metaphysics. Since perception alone gives direct and certain knowledge, Carvaka rejects inference as an independent pramana. Inference depends on vyapti, or universal relation, which cannot be established with certainty because all cases across all times and places cannot be perceived. It also rejects testimony, especially scriptural testimony, because it speaks of imperceptible entities. Therefore, Carvaka rejects God, eternal soul, karma, rebirth, heaven, hell, and moksha as not validly established. It identifies the self with the living body and regards consciousness as a product of material elements.

**Conclusion:** Thus, Carvaka is best understood as an empiricist and materialist critique of metaphysics, leading to this-worldly ethics and emphasis on worldly well-being.

### Last-minute Recall Hook

**Sense it -> accept it. Cannot establish vyapti -> doubt inference. Cannot perceive soul/God/karma -> reject transcendent entities. Matter/body is real -> this life matters.**